

TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Rasam

Peppery Tamarind Broth
The Digestive Soul of the South

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Rasam

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Rasam

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Essence, Not the Meal

The word rasam comes from the Tamil and Sanskrit-rooted term for "juice" or "essence" — an apt name for a dish that is less a soup than a distillation of pepper, tamarind, and spice, thinned to something you drink as much as eat. Long before tomatoes arrived in India with Portuguese traders in the 16th century, rasam existed in its oldest form as milagu rasam — a simple broth of black pepper, cumin, garlic, and tamarind, valued as much for its warming, digestive properties as for its flavor.

In the traditional order of a South Indian meal, rasam is not a starter but a middle course — served after the sambar-and-rice course and before the final course of plain curd rice. Its purpose is almost medicinal: the sharp hit of pepper and the acidity of tamarind are believed to aid digestion and clear the palate, a role it has played in Tamil households for generations, particularly when someone in the family has a cold.

Tomato entered the dish only in the last few centuries, giving rise to the milder, rounder tomato rasam that most people outside South India know today. Both versions remain equally beloved, chosen depending on the season, the meal, and — as many South Indian cooks will tell you — how someone in the house is feeling that day.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Essence, Not the Meal, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Traditionally the third course of a formal South Indian meal, served after sambar rice and before curd rice. Considered a home remedy for colds, sore throats, and poor digestion — pepper rasam especially. A common comfort food, often served on its own in a small steel tumbler when someone is unwell. Featured at almost every Tamil wedding and festival banquet.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	20m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small pressure cooker or saucepan for the dal
- Medium saucepan for simmering the rasam
- Small pan for the tempering
- Mortar and pestle or spice grinder for the rasam powder
- Fine sieve for straining tamarind pulp

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Rasam is best enjoyed fresh, as its bright flavor fades on standing, but it keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — reheat gently without letting it boil hard, which mutes the pepper's aroma. Rasam powder keeps airtight for 2–3 months and is worth making in bulk.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the broth

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Toor dal (split pigeon pea)	3 tbsp	40 g	3 tbsp
Tamarind, seedless	1½ tbsp	20 g	small marble-size ball
Tomato, ripe, chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Turmeric powder	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Water	3 cups	720 ml	3 katori
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Fresh coriander leaves, chopped	2 tbsp	10 g	2 tbsp

Rasam powder (or 2 tbsp store-bought)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Black peppercorns	1 tbsp	8 g	1 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tbsp	6 g	1 chammach
Coriander seeds	1 tbsp	6 g	1 chammach
Toor dal (for roasting)	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Dried red chili	1–2	1–2	1–2

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

Tempering (tadka)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach
Mustard seeds	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Garlic cloves, crushed	3–4	3–4	3–4
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

If you don't have whole spices to roast, a good store-bought rasam powder (MTR and Aachi are reliable, widely exported brands) is a very acceptable substitute. Fresh tamarind can be swapped for 1½ tsp concentrated tamarind paste, adjusted to taste. Garlic is optional in some households — omit it entirely for a more classic milagu-style rasam.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

The Base and the Spice

01 COOK THE TOOR DAL

Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with 1 cup / 240 ml water and a pinch of turmeric for 3 whistles, until soft. Mash lightly and set aside — you'll use both the dal and its cooking water.

02 PREPARE THE TAMARIND EXTRACT

Soak the tamarind in ½ cup / 120 ml warm water for 10 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract the pulp.

03 ROAST AND GRIND THE RASAM POWDER

Dry roast the peppercorns, cumin, coriander seeds, toor dal, and dried chili in a small pan over low heat until fragrant and the dal turns golden, about 2–3 minutes. Cool and grind to a coarse powder — a little texture here is traditional, unlike the fine powder used for sambar.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

The Base and the Spice, continued



Chef tip. a slightly coarse rasam powder, rather than a fine one, gives the finished broth its characteristic flecks of pepper and cumin.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Rasam

04 SIMMER THE TAMARIND AND TOMATO

In a saucepan, combine the tamarind extract, chopped tomato, turmeric, and 2 cups / 480 ml water. Bring to a simmer and cook for 8–10 minutes, until the tomato has broken down and the raw tamarind smell has softened.

05 ADD THE DAL AND RASAM POWDER

Stir in the cooked dal (with its water) and the rasam powder. Simmer gently for 5–6 minutes — do not let it boil vigorously, which can make the broth taste flat and mute the pepper's aroma.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Rasam, continued



Cooking checkpoint. rasam is ready the moment a light froth forms on the surface — this is the traditional sign to remove it from heat immediately.

06 ADD THE FINAL TEMPERING

Heat ghee in a small pan. Add mustard seeds and let them pop, then the crushed garlic, curry leaves, and asafoetida, stirring until the garlic turns golden and fragrant. Pour the sizzling tempering directly into the rasam and cover briefly to trap the aroma. Finish with chopped coriander.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Rasam, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling rasam hard or for too long is the most common mistake — it drives off the pepper's volatile aroma and leaves the broth tasting one-note sour. Treat the simmer gently, and pull it the moment it froths.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Poured over steamed rice as the second course of a formal meal, mixed by hand with a little ghee.
- Sipped on its own from a small steel tumbler, especially when someone is unwell.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl or shot glass as a warming starter before the main thali.

Family Style

- A pot kept warm at the table, ladled fresh over each person's rice as the meal progresses.

Modern Pairing

- Excellent alongside crisp idli or as a light soup course on its own with a side of papad.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Flavor Balancing

- A touch more pepper than feels necessary is traditional — rasam should have real warmth on the back of the throat.
- Never skip the final tempering; it's what gives rasam its signature aroma right as it hits the table.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Rasam powder freezes indefinitely and is worth batch-making — many households make a large jar every festival season.
- Cook the dal and tamarind base ahead, then add the tempering fresh just before serving for the best aroma.

RESTAURANT TRICK

For a clearer, more elegant restaurant-style rasam, strain out the dal solids entirely and use only the cooking water — this gives a lighter, more polished broth without losing the depth of flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

65 kcal	3 g	9 g	2 g	2 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with dal quantity and ghee used.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Milagu Rasam	the oldest form, made without tomato, relying purely on pepper, cumin, and tamarind.
Tomato Rasam	the most common modern version, rounder and milder thanks to the tomato base.
Lemon Rasam	finished with fresh lemon juice instead of tamarind, for a brighter, lighter broth.
Paruppu (Dal) Rasam	made with a higher proportion of dal for a thicker, heartier version.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why did my rasam taste bitter?

Usually over-roasted spices in the rasam powder, or boiling the broth too hard after adding it. Roast spices only until fragrant, and keep the final simmer gentle.

Can I make rasam without dal?

Yes — a simpler "neer rasam" (water rasam) skips the dal entirely for a thinner, more medicinal-style broth, common when treating a cold.

Is rasam the same as sambar?

No — rasam is thin, peppery, and served as a course on its own, while sambar is thicker, vegetable-based, and used more as a sauce over rice or dipped with idli and dosa.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Rasam powder	a coarse roasted spice blend of pepper, cumin, and coriander.
Milagu	Tamil for black pepper, the dominant note in traditional rasam.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot ghee, added at the end.
Neer rasam	a thin, dal-free "water rasam" often given to those with a cold.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Rasam

10m	20m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

BROTH

Toor dal	40 g
Tamarind	20 g
Tomato	100 g
Turmeric powder	1 g
Water	720 ml
Salt	to taste
Fresh coriander leaves	10 g

RASAM POWDER (OR 2 TBSP STORE-BOUGHT)

Black peppercorns	8 g
Cumin seeds	6 g
Coriander seeds	6 g
Toor dal	4 g
Dried red chili	1–2

TEMPERING (TADKA)

Ghee	15 ml
Mustard seeds	2 g
Garlic cloves	3–4
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch

METHOD

01 **Cook the toor dal.** Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with 1 cup / 240 ml water and a pinch of turmeric for 3 whistles, until soft.

02 **Prepare the tamarind extract.** Soak the tamarind in ½ cup / 120 ml warm water for 10 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract the pulp.

03 **Roast and grind the rasam powder.** Dry roast the peppercorns, cumin, coriander seeds, toor dal, and dried chili in a small pan over low heat until fragrant and the dal turns golden, about 2–3 minutes.

04 **Simmer the tamarind and tomato.** In a saucepan, combine the tamarind extract, chopped tomato, turmeric, and 2 cups / 480 ml water.

05 **Add the dal and rasam powder.** Stir in the cooked dal (with its water) and the rasam powder.

06 **Add the final tempering.** Heat ghee in a small pan.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Toor dal	see recipe	
☐	Tomato	100 g	
☐	Salt	to taste	
☐	Black peppercorns	8 g	
☐	Coriander seeds	6 g	
☐	Ghee	15 ml	
☐	Garlic cloves	3–4	
☐	Asafoetida	pinch	
☐	Tamarind	20 g	
☐	Turmeric powder	1 g	
☐	Fresh coriander leaves	10 g	
☐	Cumin seeds	6 g	
☐	Dried red chili	1–2	
☐	Mustard seeds	2 g	
☐	Curry leaves	8–10 leaves	

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